



GRAVESIDE

Some doors open from the other side.

A Television Series

TV-MA · 60 Minutes · 15 Episodes Per Season

Three-Season Arc · Definitive Ending



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I. LOGLINE & SERIES OVERVIEW

Series Logline

A trauma surgeon and a genealogist — two people drawn together by an inexplicable obsession with the dead — discover that certain cemeteries hold a door neither of them chose to open. Pulled into the lives of the buried, they experience history's darkest stories from opposing sides, powerless to change a single outcome but not powerless to act on what they witness. As they begin anonymously surfacing buried crimes with living consequences, someone in the present starts noticing the impossible specificity of what they know — and the slow collision between the door they opened and the world they live in becomes as dangerous as anything they've witnessed in the past.

Pitch Room One-Liner

Two people obsessed with cemetery history get exactly what they wished for — and spend three seasons trying to survive what they found.

Tone Reference

Six Feet Under's emotional architecture. Yellowjackets' dread. Deadwood's period savagery. A conspiracy thriller slowly assembling itself in the present. Dark humor running underneath everything like a fault line.

Show Overview

GRAVESIDE is a TV-MA prestige drama-horror anthology series following DR. MARA VOSS, a trauma surgeon, and ELI COLE, a forensic genealogist — a couple united by a shared and slightly obsessive fascination with historic cemeteries and the stories buried inside them. What begins as a morbid but intellectually rich hobby becomes something neither of them has a framework to explain. When they research deeply enough into a person's history and stand at their grave together, they are pulled backward. Inhabiting real people with dark pasts, experiencing the same story from opposing perspectives, powerless to intervene, unable to change a single outcome. They return at the moment of death. They carry everything they witnessed back with them.

The show operates on three tracks simultaneously. The **anthology track** delivers a new dark historical story every episode — morally complex, period-specific, violent, occasionally savage, leavened with dark humor, always grounded in human darkness rather than supernatural spectacle. The **series track** follows Mara and Eli's relationship as the transports erode their certainty about themselves, each other, and why exactly two specific people keep getting pulled through the same door. The **conspiracy track** builds in the present — because Mara and Eli have started using what they witness. Surfacing buried evidence. Anonymously correcting historical records. Delivering impossible information to journalists and investigators who don't know where it came from. Someone is starting to notice.

GRAVESIDE is not a ghost story. It is a story about what the dead leave behind, what the living inherit without knowing it, whether justice has an expiration date, and whether two people can choose each other when history has already decided they shouldn't.

II. THEMATIC CORE

The dead don't stay buried.

Not their stories. Not their consequences. Not the damage they did or the damage done to them. Every episode is an argument for this thesis delivered in a different register — tragic, horrifying, darkly comic, achingly human.

Justice has no expiration date.

The show's moral position stated plainly: buried crimes with living consequences deserve to be surfaced regardless of how much time has passed. Power protects itself across generations. The show systematically dismantles that protection one transport at a time. This thesis is bipartisan and transhistorical — corruption, abuse of power, and the erasure of inconvenient truth are human constants, not political ones.

Witness as its own form of grief.

Mara and Eli cannot change anything in the past. They can only see clearly. But seeing clearly turns out to be its own form of power — and its own form of burden. The show asks whether that is punishment or gift — and whether the answer changes depending on what you're forced to witness.

Love tested by inherited conflict.

The central relationship is the emotional engine. The transports don't just tell historical stories — they stress-test a modern relationship by forcing two people to repeatedly experience the world from opposing sides. That's a metaphor for every relationship that has ever existed, delivered through a horror-drama framework.

Whether people get to choose who they are.

The family revelation at the show's core asks a fundamental question: if your bloodline did something terrible, if the person you love comes from the people who were wronged — do you get to be different? Do you get to choose each other anyway? The show believes yes. But it makes both characters earn it.

III. THE WORLD & ITS RULES

The Cemeteries

There is no single haunted location. The phenomenon travels with Mara and Eli. Historic cemeteries across America — and potentially beyond — are all equally capable of becoming a door. Colonial New England burial grounds. The Texas State Cemetery. Gold Rush era San Francisco. Depression-era Rust Belt. Each cemetery has its own visual language — different color grading, different sound design, different atmosphere. Present-day couple scenes maintain consistent visual grammar regardless of location.

The Transport Mechanism

Never fully explained. Never confirmed as supernatural, psychological, or biological. The show presents evidence for multiple interpretations and commits to none. What is established empirically — what Mara and Eli confirm through pattern recognition:

- The transport requires both of them present at the grave simultaneously. It has never happened to either of them alone. *(Note: Raymond Chase's solo transport is an anomaly that contradicts this rule — and becomes significant in season two.)*
- It requires prior deep research into that specific person's history — genuine engagement with their story, not just facts.
- It is triggered by physical contact with the headstone after the research threshold is met. Casual contact before that threshold does nothing.
- It cannot be intentionally prevented once triggered. They have tried.
- It deposits them at a significant moment in the inhabited person's life — not always near death, sometimes years or decades before it.
- It ends at the moment of the inhabited person's death. Always.
- They return to the exact moment they left. No time passes in the present.

The Rules of Transport

- They inhabit real people who actually lived, died, and are buried in that specific grave.
- They experience opposing perspectives of the same story. Eli and Mara are never inside the same person. They are always on different sides of the same event.
- They cannot communicate with each other during a transport. They are fully inside another consciousness.
- **They do not immediately know who the other has become.** They know they are both present somewhere in the historical story but cannot identify which person the other inhabits until they return and debrief. This creates a second layer of tension within every transport. Occasionally one of them feels an inexplicable pull toward a specific person in the scene — an instinct without a name. Not enough to know. Just enough to feel. That sensation becomes a recurring motif the audience tracks across the season.
- They are aware of themselves as observers but cannot override the inhabited person's actions or words. They experience everything — sensation, emotion, memory fragments — but cannot steer.
- They cannot alter outcomes. The universe corrects itself. The ending is always the ending.
- They retain complete memory. The inhabited person is unaware of their presence.

The Physical Evidence

This is the show's most important mechanical element and its most cinematically distinctive recurring device. The people Mara and Eli inhabit leave physical evidence behind — hidden with the certainty it will never be found. A gun thrown into a specific bend of a river that still exists. A tin box buried under a specific floorboard of a building converted to condominiums. A letter sealed inside a wall cavity of a courthouse standing since 1887.

Mara and Eli know exactly where these objects are. They were there when they were hidden.

The recovery scenes are the show's most cinematic present-day set piece — a third visual register distinct from both the transport sequences and the research scenes. Mara and Eli standing at a specific bend in a river knowing exactly what they're going to find before they find it. The confidence of that action. The specific horror of being right. These objects are irrefutable in a way that archival documents cannot be — and their impossible recovery is what eventually changes Nora Vasquez's investigation from a pattern inquiry to something considerably more urgent.

The Cost

— **Emotional bleed** — the inhabited person's emotional state lingers for hours after return. A murderer's cold certainty. A victim's unresolved terror. A grieving parent's specific hollowness. This affects their relationship, their work, their sleep. It is physiological and measurable.

— **Physical toll** — extended or particularly traumatic transports leave genuine exhaustion. Something more specific and alarming begins manifesting in late season two. Medical in presentation. Inexplicable in origin.

— **Temporal erosion** — the longer the series runs the more time spent in the past begins to feel more real than the present. Both characters feel this by late season two. It is the most dangerous cost and the hardest to name.

IV. THE COUPLE

ELI COLE — The Forensic Genealogist

Eli is 38. Lean, unhurried, the kind of person who reads every historical marker at every roadside stop and means it. He has the slightly distracted quality of someone whose brain is always running a parallel process — contextualizing the present against the past, finding the historical echo in every mundane moment. Genuinely funny in a dry, poorly-timed way. He says the wrong thing at funerals and somehow gets away with it.

His younger brother died at eleven — a drowning, ruled accidental, in a small Northeast town with a long memory and a short tolerance for questions. Eli was nine. He watched his family's grief calcify into silence. The cemetery became the only place he could go and feel like his brother still existed. He started reading other headstones. Started wondering about those lives. The obsession grew outward from that original wound and never stopped.

Professionally gifted — specifically at finding people who were deliberately erased from records. Families economically destroyed, histories rewritten by the powerful, names removed from the official account. His flaw is detachment — he processes everything as story. It protects him and keeps him at a half-step remove from his own life. The transports will make that impossible to maintain.

MARA VOSS — The Trauma Surgeon

Mara is 36. Precise, quick, comfortable with silence in a way that reads as intimidating until you know her. She has the surgeon's quality of being completely present in a crisis and slightly elsewhere everywhere else. Laughs at things she shouldn't. Doesn't laugh at things she should. Her dark humor is sharper than Eli's — more caustic, more specific, occasionally alarming to people who don't know her well.

Her father died when she was twelve — sudden cardiac event, grimly ironic to her. A doctor who couldn't see his own death coming. She processed it the way she processes everything: by needing to understand the mechanism. She became a trauma surgeon because she wanted to be the person in the room who changes the outcome. The transports are a specific kind of torture for her — she is constitutionally, professionally unable to accept that the ending is fixed. Every transport is a war between her instincts and the rules of the mechanism.

Her flaw is control. She manages everything — her OR, her relationships, her grief. The transports strip that control completely. By mid-season two it begins affecting her surgical performance in ways she cannot explain to colleagues.

Their Relationship

Together three years at series start. They met at a cemetery — reached for the same research book in a historic New England cemetery archive on the same afternoon. Coffee. Back the next day together. Not married. Conversations have happened. Nothing resolved. Both carry enough unexamined history that full commitment carries particular weight neither has been ready for. The show begins at the moment before that changes.

They fight well — specific, intelligent, occasionally savage. Tender in private in ways neither fully shows the world. Eli makes her laugh in a way nobody else does. Mara is the only person Eli allows to see the grief he's been carrying since he was nine.

The asymmetry: Eli drives the cemetery obsession initially. As the transports escalate that dynamic inverts — Mara becomes the one who needs to understand what's happening while Eli is being pulled somewhere he's not sure he wants to go.

V. SUPPORTING CHARACTERS

RAYMOND CHASE — The Ally

Raymond is 39. Investigative historian. His byline appears in serious long-form publications at the intersection of prestige journalism and academic history — the kind of work that is respected, occasionally celebrated, and consistently makes institutional subjects uncomfortable. He consults on historical legal cases: wrongful conviction reviews, land claim disputes, accountability investigations. He has a public profile modest enough to move through the world unrecognized but credible enough that his sourcing is never questioned.

Sharp, restless, constitutionally unable to leave a question alone. His humor is quick and specific and slightly inappropriate — which puts him immediately in the same register as Mara and Eli. He is also genuinely careful in the way that someone carrying an enormous private secret for several years becomes careful. A quality of watchfulness that reads as intensity until you understand what's underneath it.

His own transport happened four years before the series begins. A single event. Alone. A cemetery in rural New England during research for a piece on a 19th century land dispute. He touched a headstone and went back — alone, without another person present, which according to every pattern Mara and Eli will eventually establish should have been impossible. He came back. Wrote the piece. Never told anyone. He has been researching the mechanism quietly ever since. He found Eli's published work eighteen months before the series starts and recognized something in the specificity of it — a quality of knowing that goes beyond what the cited sources should support. He has been paying careful attention. He does not approach them. He waits. He is very good at waiting.

His function as ally: institutional cover for evidence surfacing, journalistic credentials to receive and publish anonymous tips under legitimate source protection, academic access to create paper trails that make Eli's impossible archival finds look like methodical professional research. He is the shield between what Mara and Eli know and how the world sees them knowing it.

The Solo Transport Anomaly: Raymond's single solo transport breaks the established rule that both Mara and Eli must be present. This anomaly is planted in season one and becomes significant in season two — either his bloodline connects to the same historical thread, or the mechanism made a specific exception for a reason connected to why he needed to find them. That question remains open until season two.

DETECTIVE NORA VASQUEZ — The Antagonist

Nora is 44. Homicide detective turned cold case investigator for a regional task force operating across multiple Northeastern jurisdictions. Sharp, methodical, constitutionally unable to leave a thread unpulled. She has spent her career working cases that powerful people wanted closed and has the professional scars to show for it.

Her personal wound: her grandfather was convicted of a crime in the 1960s that she has always believed he didn't commit. The conviction destroyed her family's reputation across two generations. She became a detective partly to understand how the machinery of justice fails people and partly — though she'd never say this out loud — to fix it where she can.

She is not a villain. She is a person doing her job colliding with two people doing something she has no framework for. Her internal conflict — the information is good, the sourcing is impossible, and someone who keeps delivering justice anonymously is either a hero or a threat depending on which day she's asked — makes her the show's most morally complex supporting character. By mid-season two she knows it's Mara and Eli. By late season two she has enough to move on them. What she does with that is the show's most consequential moral question outside the central relationship.

DR. FELIX OKAFOR — Mara's Colleague

Felix is 40. Attending trauma surgeon at Mara's hospital and her closest professional friend — the person most likely to notice when she's not right. Brilliant, competitive in the way surgeons are competitive, perceptive enough to see through Mara's performance of fine when it starts slipping. He provides the professional world the present-day scenes need — the hospital as a place with its own stakes, its own dark humor, its own culture of people who deal with death daily and cope with varying degrees of success. He doesn't know about the transports for most of season one. When he eventually figures out something is seriously wrong with Mara it won't be the transports he identifies — it'll be the emotional bleed and physical toll manifesting in ways that have clinical explanations he keeps getting wrong.

VI. TONE & FORMAT

Tone

Dark drama with horror textures and a conspiracy thriller slowly assembling in the present. Dark humor running underneath everything as a fault line — primarily in present-day dynamics and supporting character interactions. The transports stay dark. Human darkness — not supernatural spectacle — is the source of all horror.

Rating & Format

- TV-MA. Profanity, nudity, violence, and selective gore used with intention and restraint.
- Each mature element serves character or period authenticity. One genuinely disturbing image per episode lands harder than constant assault.
- 60-minute episodes. 15 episodes per season. Three season arc with a definitive ending.

Visual Language

Present-day scenes — clean, cool, slightly clinical. Each cemetery and transport period has its own distinct palette, texture, and sound design. The past feels more saturated, more physical, more overwhelming than the present. That ratio intensifies as the series progresses.

Episode Structure

- **Act One** — Present day. The couple, the cemetery, the research, the trigger. Supporting characters establish present-day stakes.
- **Acts Two and Three** — The transport. Intercut between Eli's perspective and Mara's. Opposing angles of the same story building toward the same inevitable ending. Neither knowing who the other has become until they return.
- **Act Four** — Return. The debrief — including the recognition of who each inhabited. Physical evidence recovered. Records corrected. Anonymous tips delivered. The antagonist thread advanced. The relationship absorbing the impact.

Episode Type Classification (internal use)

- **Type A** — Pure anthology. Dark history, self-contained, third act payoff primary focus.
- **Type B** — Anthology with present-day relationship and mythology weighted heavily.
- **Type C** — Ancestor episode. Mythology forward. One or two per season. Not announced or labeled.

VII. SERIES ARC — THREE SEASONS

Season One — The Door Opens

Discovery and first consequences. The transports begin without warning and escalate in intensity. Mara and Eli begin using what they witness — cautiously at first, then with growing purpose. Anonymous tips reach journalists and investigators. Nora Vasquez begins noticing a pattern. Raymond Chase moves from background resource to revealed ally. The family connection exists in the margins. By the finale the couple knows the door exists, knows they are somehow the key, and knows someone in the present is looking for them.

Season Two — The Cost Becomes Real

Escalation on all three tracks. Transports get longer and more destabilizing. The conspiracy track accelerates — Nora gets closer, and people whose buried crimes are being surfaced begin looking for the source with resources that dwarf Nora's. The family conflict surfaces as undeniable. Raymond reveals more of what he knows. The physical cost reaches a crisis point. Season ends with the family connection confirmed, Nora in a position of terrible choice, and Raymond's solo transport anomaly demanding an answer.

Season Three — Reckoning

All three tracks converge. Ancestor episodes become the structural spine. The original conflict fully excavated. A more powerful threat forces a public reckoning that puts everything at risk. Raymond's full story revealed. The final transport: the original moment of conflict between the two families, witnessed from both sides simultaneously for the first time. The mechanism completes its purpose. The transports stop. The couple decides who they are now that they know everything.

The Series Ending

The mechanism is explained not through exposition but through experience. The final transport is the explanation — two people from both bloodlines finally witnessing the truth of what happened from both sides simultaneously. The act of genuine witness, for the first time, completes something unresolved for over a century. The transports stop because they were never random. These two specific people were necessary. Once they've done what only they could do, the door closes. The couple chooses each other. That choice is not easy or clean. It is earned.

VIII. THE FAMILY MYTHOLOGY

The Two Bloodlines

Eli descends from the COLE family. Mara descends from the VOSS family. The original conflict occurred in the late 1800s in a small Northeast city — specific location withheld from the audience until late season two. Both families made choices. Both families paid prices. The truth was deliberately buried and surviving accounts from both sides are incomplete, self-serving, and contradictory.

The conflict involved a death ruled one thing that was another. Both families believed they were the wronged party. The resolution destroyed one family economically and drove the other from the region entirely. No one who lived through it ever told the full truth.

The Ancestor Episodes

One or two per season. When inhabiting an ancestor something feels subtly different — uncomfortable recognition, like hearing music you've never heard but somehow already know. The audience is positioned to recognize ancestor episodes slightly ahead of the couple. Not labeled. Not announced. The recognition arrives the same way it arrives for Mara and Eli — gradually, then all at once.

IX. SEASON ONE — EPISODE OUTLINE

15 Episodes

EPISODE 1 — "PLOT"

Pilot — Cold Open In The Past, Flash Back, Present Day Build

Cold open — no title card, no context. We are in the past. Period setting, period clothing. Two people moving through someone else's life with a disorientation that reads as wrong without explanation. We watch for two to three minutes until something in the historical story reaches a point of crisis — then hard cut to black. Title card: GRAVESIDE.

Cut to: six months earlier. Mara and Eli on a road trip, arguing affectionately about a cemetery detour. We establish their dynamic — her sharpness, his distraction, three years of specific intimacy and dark humor. We learn through naturalistic conversation the broad shape of their histories. His brother. Her father. The grief underneath the hobby neither of them fully names. Felix appears briefly via a hospital call. Raymond surfaces as a name — Eli leaves him a research voicemail, casual, established.

The episode builds toward the moment the cold open was pulled from — the same transport, now earned, now contextualized. The world goes white. They separate into the past. The cold open sequence resumes from where it cut. We now understand who these people are and what it costs them to be here. The episode ends where the cold open ended. Except now it means something entirely different.

EPISODE 2 — "WHAT HAPPENED TO MARGARET FINCH"

Type A — Pure Anthology · 1890s Northeast

First full transport. Eli inhabits THOMAS FINCH, respected mill foreman. Mara inhabits AUGUSTUS VALE, mill owner. Margaret Finch — Thomas's wife — died under circumstances ruled accidental. Thomas knows it wasn't. Augustus knows it wasn't. The audience understands the full picture before either man does. Neither Mara nor Eli knows who the other has become. Eli feels an inexplicable unease around Vale — something in the man's evasiveness. He won't understand until the debrief that he was feeling Mara. Dark, period-specific, violent in one concentrated act.

Physical Evidence: Vale disposed of the instrument used in Margaret's death — wrapped in oilcloth — in a specific bend in a mill river that still exists. Eli knows exactly where.

Third Act Payoff: They recover the oilcloth package from the riverbed. Eli locates the misfiled inquest document he now knows exists. Both submitted anonymously — the physical evidence to a regional historical crimes unit, the document to a historical archive. Margaret Finch's official cause of death is corrected after 130 years. The show's moral engine turns over for the first time.

EPISODE 3 — "THE GOOD DOCTOR"

Type B — Anthology / Present Day Heavy · 1920s Texas

First trip after episode two. Eli has been cataloguing the pattern obsessively. Mara has buried herself in surgical shifts. The tension between them sits unaddressed. Felix notices Mara is off — she deflects cleanly but he files it. Transport: Eli inhabits DR. CALVIN MARSH, prominent physician. Mara inhabits RUTH DELANEY, a patient's wife. Marsh conducted medical experimentation on trusting patients. Ruth's husband was one of them. The horror is intimate and slow — surgical instruments, procedural detail that hits differently given Mara's profession.

Physical Evidence: Marsh kept a private experimental ledger hidden inside a false bottom of a medical cabinet donated to a hospital archive in 1931.

Third Act Payoff: The ledger is recovered. An anonymous tip to a medical journalist begins an inquiry into the still-existing institution built on Marsh's reputation. Mara watches the first news story about the inquiry from her office and leaves early without explanation.

EPISODE 4 — "REPUBLIC"

Type A — Pure Anthology · Republic of Texas Era, 1840s

Texas State Cemetery. Eli inhabits JAMES WHITMORE CADE, land commissioner and public hero — his name still on a building that stands. Mara inhabits CONSUELA REYES, a Mexican landowner whose family's claim Cade dismantled through legal manipulation and outright fraud. The dark humor lives entirely in Cade's absolute self-righteousness. In one charged moment, Eli forces a signature Mara's hand trembles to resist — neither knows it's the other until the debrief.

Physical Evidence: Cade concealed the original Reyes land grant — the legitimate document that would have invalidated his claim — in a strongbox buried beneath the floor of a building that still stands, now a restaurant.

Third Act Payoff: The strongbox is recovered during a historical preservation inspection Eli arranges. The Reyes land grant surfaces publicly. The building bearing Cade's name becomes a question someone is now publicly asking. Their first real post-transport fight — not really about Cade and Consuela.

EPISODE 5 — "LULLABY"

Type B — Emotionally Heaviest of Season · 1900s Northeast

A child's grave. Eli resists researching it. Mara pushes. A woman accused of killing her child — the town records treated it as closed and simple. Eli inhabits REVEREND SILAS HORNE, who led the community's judgment. Mara inhabits AGNES PRUETT, the accused mother. Agnes was failed by every system around her. The Reverend's absolute certainty is the horror. The child's death is not shown directly but its weight is everywhere.

Physical Evidence: Horne kept Agnes's private correspondence — letters documenting her deterioration and the community's abandonment — locked in a church strongbox transferred to a diocesan archive in 1912 and never opened.

Third Act Payoff: The letters are found exactly where Eli said they would be. Agnes's great-great-granddaughter receives a complete documented account. She responds publicly in a historical society newsletter. Raymond Chase reads it. We see him read it. He makes a note. First time Raymond pays specific attention to something they've done.

EPISODE 6 — "GOLDEN SPIKE"

Type A — Pure Anthology · 1860s American West

A railroad cemetery. Chinese immigrant laborers buried in a barely-maintained section — many unnamed. Eli's research recovers one name. Eli inhabits CORNELIUS PHELPS, railroad company supervisor. Mara inhabits WEI LIANG, a laborer. A specific act of violence against the labor camp — covered up, never prosecuted. The dark humor is entirely absent. The audience should feel its absence.

Physical Evidence: *Phelps buried a company memorandum authorizing the violence inside a locked document case in the crawlspace of a company building that still stands as a municipal office.*

Third Act Payoff: *The document case is recovered. An anonymous tip blows open a story on the corporate successor conglomerate. A congressional inquiry into historical labor violations is announced. Nora Vasquez appears for the first time — interviewed as a cold case consultant. One comment about the anonymous sourcing is professionally precise and slightly unnerving. Eli watches. Doesn't mention it to Mara.*

EPISODE 7 — "THE VOSS GRAVE"

Type C — FIRST ANCESTOR EPISODE · Late 1800s

Not announced as an ancestor episode. A mid-size Northeast city cemetery. Mara notices a headstone with her family name. Dismisses it. Eli researches anyway. HILDEGARD VOSS, died 1887, cause of death: fever. Transport: Eli inhabits a man named AUGUST COLE — a name he will not consciously register until later. Mara inhabits Hildegard Voss. A dispute between two families, nature deliberately obscured. A death that may not have been a fever. One moment — brief, charged — where August Cole and Hildegard Voss are in the same room. Eli and Mara, across from each other without knowing it.

Third Act Payoff: *Deliberately muted. Eli searches Hildegard Voss. Dead end. He closes the laptop but doesn't close the file. The payoff here is the thread planted, not resolved. Nora second appearance — her board is shown for the first time. It is methodical, troubling, and very good.*

EPISODE 8 — "THE SENATOR'S WIFE"

Type A — Pure Anthology · Early 1900s Texas

Texas State Cemetery. A prominent politician's grave. His wife buried beside him — smaller stone, weathered. Eli inhabits SENATOR HARLAN CROSS, celebrated reformer. Mara inhabits DOROTHY CROSS, his wife. The episode dismantles the public legend. Cross's private conduct was a separate jurisdiction. Dorothy knew everything. Made calculations. The season's sharpest dark humor — Cross is pompous and self-dramatizing and Eli's internal experience of him produces moments of genuine absurdity that cut against the darkness.

Physical Evidence: *Dorothy Cross kept a diary documenting her husband's private conduct — hidden inside a false backing of a trunk donated to a historical society in 1931.*

Third Act Payoff: *The diary is found precisely where Eli said. Its contents donated to a university archive. A biography of Cross is pulled pending review. The impossibility of Eli knowing about the diary is the first time the anonymity starts to crack. Nora notes it specifically on her board.*

EPISODE 9 — "FEVER GROUND"

Type B — Anthology / Mythology Development · 1870s South

A yellow fever epidemic cemetery. Eli inhabits DR. WARREN PELL, celebrated physician who stayed when others fled. Mara inhabits CELESTINE BROUSSARD, a free Black woman running an informal medical operation treating people the official establishment wouldn't see. The horror is the machinery of erasure — Celestine's work absorbed into Pell's official record without credit, her name attached to nothing she built.

Physical Evidence: *Celestine's original patient records — in her handwriting, under her name — stored in a locked cabinet in her home, subsequently inventoried under Pell's estate name. The cabinet is in a university archive.*

Third Act Payoff: *Formal attribution challenge filed. Celestine Broussard credited as author and founder. A historical marker is proposed. Raymond calls Eli after this one — oblique, warm, slightly strange. Eli keeps thinking about the call. Return: First episode where Mara explicitly says she doesn't want to do this anymore. First time she means it.*

EPISODE 10 — "THE INHERITANCE"

Type A — Pure Anthology · 1930s Rust Belt Northeast

Depression-era cemetery. VICTOR HALE, died 1931. Eli inhabits WALTER HALE, Victor's brother. Mara inhabits EDNA HALE, Victor's wife. Walter's elaborate self-delusion is darkly funny until it builds toward murder. Edna knew everything. The horror is intimate, domestic, and economic.

Physical Evidence: *Walter disposed of evidence — specific financial documents and one personal item — in a locked strongbox dropped into the foundation of a building during construction in 1932. The building still stands.*

Third Act Payoff: *The strongbox is recovered. Documentary evidence submitted to a probate attorney. A civil claim is filed. The Hale family's public response makes local news. Nora briefs a colleague — the pattern now has a shape she can describe. Her colleague's silence tells her she has something real.*

EPISODE 11 — "SALT"

Type B — Anthology · 1600s Colonial New England

The oldest cemetery they've visited. A woman tried and executed during a lesser-known regional witch panic — not Salem, somewhere smaller, less documented. Eli inhabits MAGISTRATE EZRA POOLE. Mara inhabits PATIENCE GRAY, the accused. The trial documented through both perspectives. The horror is institutional. The gore period-specific and concentrated in the execution sequence. Dark humor completely absent — as in Episode 6. The audience recognizes what that absence signals.

Physical Evidence: *Poole kept a private record of the trial in which he documented his own doubts about the verdict — then buried those doubts in justification. Hidden inside the foundation stone of a church that still stands.*

Third Act Payoff: *Eli submits a formal exoneration petition to the state legislature. The petition generates a news story. Nora sees it. This time she doesn't just clip it. She makes a call. Return: Eli reads Patience Gray's name aloud very carefully, very slowly. That's the scene.*

EPISODE 12 — "WHAT AUGUST COLE KNEW"

Type C — SECOND ANCESTOR EPISODE · Late 1800s

Eli finds the name August Cole in his research notes weeks after Episode 7. He researches alone first. August Cole, died 1889, same Northeast city as Hildegard Voss. Their names appear in the same documents. He tells Mara. She goes quiet in a specific way. They drive to the cemetery without discussing what they might find. Transport: Eli inhabits August Cole directly. Mara inhabits CLARA VOSS — Hildegard's sister, who survived. The Cole-Voss conflict begins to take shape. For the first time the pull during transport is unmistakable for both of them.

Third Act Payoff: *Deliberately withheld. They don't surface anything. They sit with it. The absence of the third act mechanism is the statement. Mara says: 'I think we need to talk about our families.' Nora calls Eli directly for the first time — legitimate professional pretext. Brief, cordial, and deeply alarming.*

EPISODE 13 — "THE PHOTOGRAPHER"

Type A — Pure Anthology · 1880s Northeast

Deliberate breathing room after the ancestor revelation. A photographer whose work was partially destroyed. Eli inhabits COMMISSIONER ALDOUS BRETT, city official who ordered the photographs destroyed. Mara inhabits NORA CAFFREY, whose work documented poverty, institutional abuse, and the human cost of industrial expansion. Not killed. Systematically discredited, impoverished, and erased.

Physical Evidence: *A cache of Caffrey's surviving original prints hidden inside a locked cabinet in a private building that became a public library.*

Third Act Payoff: *Attribution documentation submitted to three museums currently holding Caffrey photographs listed as unknown. All three reattribute. Raymond Chase publishes a piece about the reattribution under his own byline — first time his name appears in proximity to their work in a way Nora can trace.*

EPISODE 14 — "GROUND TRUTH"

Type B — Present Day Heavy · No Transport · Mythology Escalation

No transport. Research, relationship, and consequence. Mara and Eli follow the Cole and Voss threads. The genealogical record is incomplete, contradictory, deliberately obscured. Raymond comes in person — first time this season. He looks at the research spread across their dining room table and says something oblique that neither fully understands yet. He is clearly on the verge of telling them something. He doesn't. Not yet. Felix pushes harder than he has before. Mara gives him slightly more than she intended — not the truth, but enough that his concern shifts registers.

Final act: Nora briefs her supervisor formally. Authorization for a formal inquiry. She stands in the hallway afterward. Whatever she expected to feel is not what she feels. Mara and Eli find what they've been looking for. They book flights.

EPISODE 15 — "WHAT THE DEAD OWE THE LIVING"

Season Finale · Type C — Ancestor Episode

The cemetery. Two headstones — one Cole, one Voss — placed in deliberate proximity. The research complete. They don't touch the headstones immediately. The season's culminating conversation first — everything the transports have cost them, everything they've surfaced, what it means that they are standing here. The dark humor surfaces once — briefly, in the way it does when people are about to do something they can't undo and need one moment of lightness first.

The transport: Eli inhabits the Cole ancestor at the center of the original conflict. Mara inhabits the Voss ancestor. The editing tighter than any previous episode — the same moments from both sides in immediate succession. The original conflict unfolds. Morally ambiguous, human, devastating, true. Neither ancestor a villain. Neither a victim. The death at the center of everything shown — not graphically but completely. During the transport the pull between them is overwhelming — they are directly opposed in the central moment of the conflict, looking at each other across the event that defined both their bloodlines, still not knowing.

They return. Night. Cemetery. Neither speaks for a long time. Mara says something that is not an answer to anything but is the only true thing available in this moment. Eli responds. The camera pulls back — away from them, up through the cemetery, past the headstones, past the tree line. Cut to: Nora Vasquez at her desk. Late. She adds two names to her board. MARA VOSS. ELI COLE. Black.

GRAVESIDE

Created by Cory Armer

Series Bible — Final Draft

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